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INDIA AND THE EMERGING SINO–IRANIAN PARTNERSHIP

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This chapter addresses how India is managing the rise of China by examining the thickening of Chinese – Iranian relations and India's response to that thickening. The thesis advanced here is that the evolution of ties between the People's Republic of China (PRC) and the Islamic Republic of Iran (IRI) over the past decade, especially during a two-year period following the July 2015 conclusion of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) between Iran and the P5+1 (the five permanent members of the UN Security Council plus Germany), added a new dimension to China's rivalry with India. The JCPOA and the lifting of international sanctions in exchange for Iran's shelving of its nuclear weapons programmes in effect opened the door to intense rivalry between Beijing and New Delhi for cooperation with Iran. Beijing rushed through that door to Tehran, and New Delhi soon followed. The China–Iran strategic partnership announced during Xi Jinping's January 2016 visit to Tehran reflected some fundamental shifts in China's approach to Iran and expanded PRC–IRI cooperation into previously taboo areas of military cooperation. Xi's visit also opened the prospect of Iran's integration into China's Belt and Road